

Setting Up the File

Preparing InDesign Before You Build Anything

A grid means nothing on top of a messy file.

Before we build anything, InDesign has to be set up like a professional environment.

Why Today Matters

Baseline grids, margins, and modules all live inside an InDesign file, and none of them work if the file underneath is a mess. Today is not about the grid. It's about the file the grid will eventually sit inside.

- 1 Configure a new document with the right units, size, and page setup**
- 2 Reset your workspace, then activate the panels you'll use**
- 3 Group and dock those panels so the workspace stays usable**
- 4 Set up parent pages for the page types that repeat across your portfolio**
- 5 Organize content into a locked, non-printing four-layer system**
- 6 Save the whole setup as a workspace you can reload every class**

Document Setup

Before anything else exists, a document has to. Every setting here becomes the foundation the rest of the term builds on.

Units

Set to Points, under Preferences > Units & Increments.

Facing Pages

Turn on, so spreads behave like a real printed book.

Page Size

612 × 792 pt (8.5 × 11 in, Letter), or your chosen Letter-compatible proportion, never a placeholder default.

WHY IT MATTERS

Units, page size, and facing pages can't be changed painlessly later, everything placed after this point measures itself against these settings.

Get this wrong and every margin, image, and text box you place has to be re-measured by hand.

Why Points, Not Inches

You just set your units to Points. That isn't a preference, it's what keeps everything else this term measurable.

TYPE IS ALREADY IN POINTS

Font size and leading have been measured in points, in every layout tool, InDesign included, since long before you opened this file. Setting your document to inches doesn't change that. It just means your ruler and your type are speaking two different units.

One Unit, Start to Finish

A page already in points needs no conversion later. A page in inches has to be switched over before the twelve-point system arrives next class, and everything you've already placed has to be re-checked against it.

WHY IT MATTERS

Next class, one number, twelve points, governs every margin, gutter, and column in this file. That stays simple only if the file is already speaking points.

Set it once, in Preferences > Units & Increments, and you're done. No conversion, ever, for the rest of the term.

The Workspace Reset

Old panels from old projects clutter your screen and slow you down. Start every new file the same way: a blank slate.

- 1 Go to the Workspace Switcher, in the top-right corner**
- 2 Select Essentials, then select Reset Essentials**
- 3 This clears old clutter and gives you a blank slate to build your system**

Activate Your Core Panels

Open the specific tools this setup requires, all from the Window menu. These aren't just today's tools, you'll open this same set every session for the rest of the term.

PANEL	PATH	WHAT IT'S FOR
Pages & Layers	Window > Pages, Window > Layers	Your primary navigation and structural hierarchy tools
Links	Window > Links	Tracks your placed project images and external drawings
Align	Window > Object & Layout > Align	Positions elements precisely relative to each other
Paragraph Styles	Window > Styles > Paragraph Styles	Your most important tool for maintaining consistent type
Properties	Window > Properties	Shows every attribute of your selected object in one place
Control	Window > Control	Contextual toolbar that changes with your tool or selection, for quick numeric edits

Organize the Dock

A scattered workspace works against you. Group and dock your panels so the tools you need are always exactly where you expect them.

- 1 Group Panels:** drag one panel's tab onto another until a blue highlight appears, then release
- 2 Docking:** drag the whole group to the right edge of the screen until a blue bar appears
- 3 Collapse to Icons:** click the double-arrow at the top of the dock for more screen space

Parent Page Architecture

Parent pages are repeating page templates. Set one up once, and every page built from it, present and future, updates automatically.

A · INTRO PARENT

A minimal layout for the project title splash page: the entry point for each project section.

Elements

Project title area, date/location.

B · PROJECT PARENT

The standard content layout, with a fixed project title placeholder the reader can always return to for orientation. No margins or grid guides yet, that's next class.

Elements

Running header, content placeholder.

The Four-Layer System

Everything you place belongs on one of four layers, always in this stacking order, top to bottom.

LAYER	STACK POSITION	WHAT GOES HERE
04_Text	Top	Titles, descriptions, page numbers. Kept on top so type is never buried under an image.
03_Images	Upper middle	Renderings, photographs, and site photos. Isolated here so you can preflight and swap links without touching text.
02_Drawings	Lower middle	Plans, sections, elevations, and diagrams: technical line work, kept separate from photographic images so either can be shown or hidden on its own.
01_Guides	Bottom, non-printing	Placeholder boxes and alignment markers. Lock this layer and uncheck Print Layer so it never appears in the exported PDF.

Why separate layers, not one flat file? Lock what you're not touching, hide what's still in progress, and nothing gets selected by accident once a spread has fifty items on it.

Why Paragraph Styles

You just opened the Paragraph Styles panel. Here's what it's for, and why it's open today even though you won't use it yet.

WHY DEFINE THEM AT ALL

A paragraph style is a saved recipe: font, size, leading, color, all under one name. Apply "Body Text" to a paragraph and it looks right. Decide body text should be 11 points instead of 10, and you change the recipe once, not fifty spreads by hand.

Without One

Every text frame gets formatted by eye, one at a time, and no two frames match exactly by the end of the term.

WHY THE PANEL IS OPEN TODAY

You won't define Title, Subtitle, Body Text, and Caption until next class, once the twelve-point baseline exists for them to lock onto.

But the panel goes into your saved workspace today, alongside Pages, Layers, and Align, so Session 05 starts with the tool already in reach, not another trip to the Window menu.

Save Your Workspace

Do this once and you never have to rebuild your panel setup again, every file for the rest of the term can open into exactly this layout.

HOW TO SAVE IT

1. Go to the Workspace Switcher > New Workspace
2. Name it something you'll recognize, e.g. "Portfolio System"
3. It now appears in the Workspace Switcher every time you open InDesign

WHAT'S NEXT

No grid work today, no baseline, no margins, no columns. That's next class: the 12-point baseline and modular grid, built on top of the file you set up today.

Before You Start Laying Out Content

Every one of these has to be true before you place a single real image or line of text. Skip one now and you're undoing work later, not saving time.

- 1 Document set up in points, facing pages on, page size 612 x 792 pt (8.5 x 11 in, Letter)**
- 2 Workspace reset, seven core panels open: Pages, Layers, Links, Align, Paragraph Styles, Properties, Control**
- 3 Panels grouped and docked so the workspace stays usable**
- 4 Two parent pages built: A-Intro and B-Project**
- 5 Four layers created in order, 01_Guides locked and non-printing**
- 6 Workspace saved under its own name, ready to reload next class**
- 7 Setup Checklist filled out and ready to submit with your file**

Quick Reference

Keep this open while you work.

ACTION	MAC	WINDOWS
Preview Mode	W	W
Open Preferences	Cmd+K	Ctrl+K
Show/Hide Guides	Cmd+;	Ctrl+;
Snap to Guides	Shift+Cmd+;	Shift+Ctrl+;
Place File	Cmd+D	Ctrl+D
Fit Spread in Window	Opt+Cmd+0	Alt+Ctrl+0